

PyCon India 2012

For Diehard Fans of Python

Being the hub of software development and off-shoring, Bengaluru plays host to a number of conferences, many of them related to FOSS. PyCon India is one such show that has been increasing in popularity over the past few years.

Every year, since 2009, enthusiasts of Python, the free and open source programming language created by Guido van Rossum, and used in everything from embedded systems to Web frameworks and space shuttles, have been congregating for an annual conference on the language in and around Bengaluru.

The conference was flagged off in 2009, as a result of discussions in 'BangPypers', a community that began in the city way back in early 2005 in order to bring together Python programming enthusiasts. The first conference was held at the Indian Institute of Science in Bengaluru.

Noufal Ibrahim, a Python programmer who works as a consultant for the Internet Archive in the city, played the key role in getting the first PyCon India on the ground. He reminisces about his experiences: "I was always interested in Python and the larger community but had never done anything significant for it. I attended a meeting of the BangPypers and there was some talk of conducting a PyCon in India. It seemed like a project that was a mix of the impossible and the attainable, which made it irresistible. I jumped at the opportunity and that led to the first PyCon in 2009."

Passionate people like Noufal and Anand Chitipothu, who has been the Web master of the PyCon India websites, have been instrumental in the successful run of the conferences since then.

In 2010, PyCon India was organised in Bengaluru; it moved to Pune in 2011. The organisers of this conference have formed a society aptly called the Indian Python Software Society (IPSS). The late programmer and free software thinker, Kenneth Gonsalves, had played a key role in registering the society and served as its president for the first year.

This year the conference will be held at Dharmaram Vidyalakshmetram at the Christ University Campus in Bengaluru from September 28 to 30. The conference highlights are keynotes by Django co-founder Jacob Kaplan-Moss, and PSF director and author Dr David Mertz. There will also be a number of other interesting talks and tutorials on a variety of topics related to Python.

IPSS works closely with its parent organisation, the Python Software Foundation (PSF), which holds the intellectual property rights to the Python programming language. PSF is sponsoring PyCon India this year.



The other supporters of the conference are Red Hat and Enthought, the scientific Python company. Enthought is the platinum sponsor and Red Hat the gold sponsor of the event.

The organisers of PyCon India have seen support for the language and the conference grow steadily since the days of BangPypers and the first PyCon India. Last year, in Pune, the conference attracted over 700 delegates, with large numbers coming from the academic community. This year, the organisers expect a similar or even bigger audience, considering the increased popularity of the language and its adoption within the software profession.

Python is a versatile language. Being free and open, it is ideally suited for start-ups and small companies that can work freely on their ideas without worrying about intellectual property or licensing encumbrances. That is not to say that it isn't suitable for large companies. Python finds a fit in almost any conceivable software project—whether it is that hobby application you work on during your weekends at home, or that mission-critical software framework that holds together the businesses of Fortune 500 companies.

You can learn more about PyCon India 2012 by visiting the conference website at <http://in.pycon.org>.

We raise a toast to Python and wish PyCon India all success! 

By Anand B Pillai

Anand B Pillai is a software developer in Bengaluru. He is the founder of BangPypers, a member of the PSF, and a key member in the PyCon India organising committee. He has written a column on Python programming for LFY in the past. He can be contacted at abpillai@gmail.com